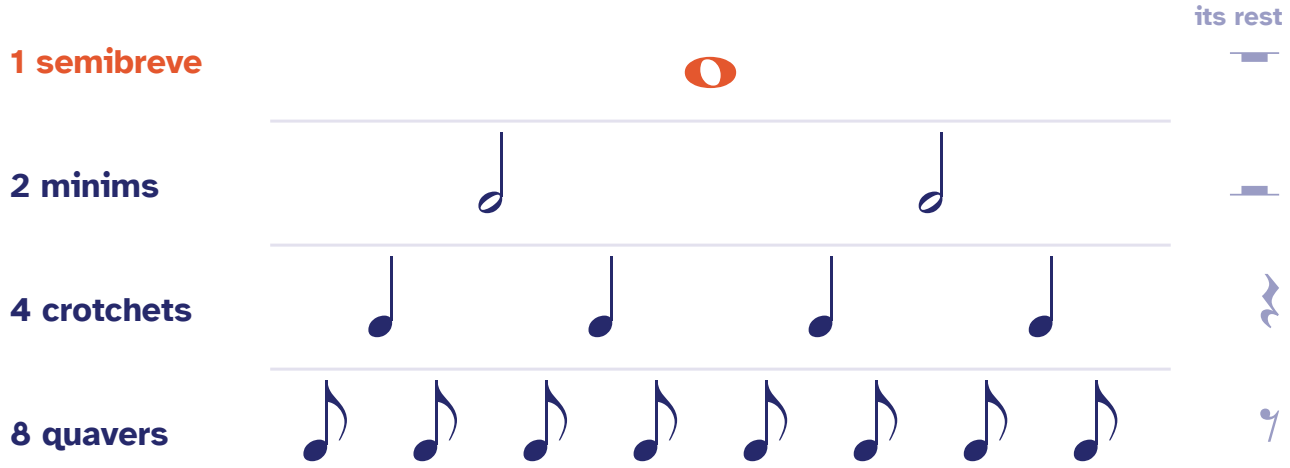PART II · TIME · 2

Notes and rests

Music is made of sounds and silences. A **note** shows how long a sound lasts; a **rest** shows how long a silence lasts, and you count it just as carefully.

THE SECRET

Each note is half the one above it, and every note has a rest twin.

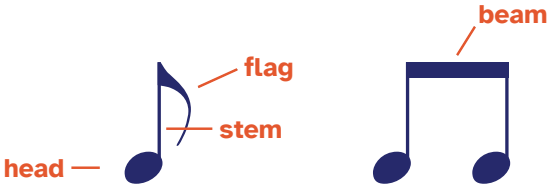


Each note splits into two of the next
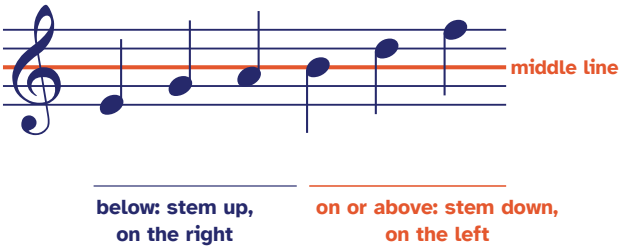
Counting quavers: say the beat's number, then "&" halfway to the next beat: "1 & 2 & 3 & 4 &".

Head, stem, flag

The **head** sits on a line or in a space. Every note but the semibreve has a **stem**. A **flag** halves the note; quavers side by side share a **beam** instead.



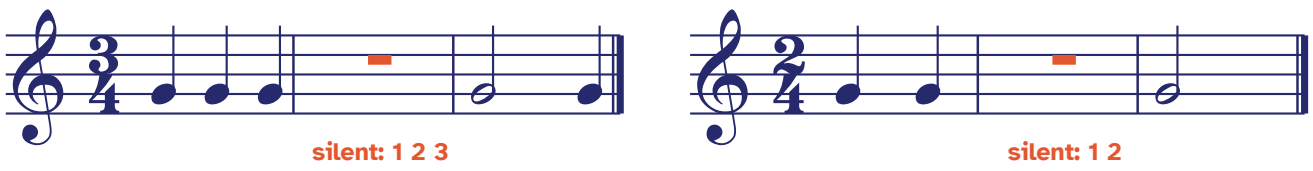
Which way does the stem go?



The stem never changes the note's length: it only keeps the page tidy.
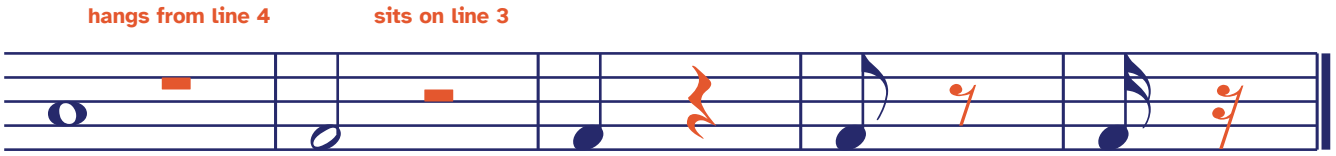
THE SEMIBREVE REST'S SPECIAL POWER

Most rests last a fixed number of beats. The **semibreve rest** can also mean **a whole bar of silence** in any time signature: 4 beats in 4/4, but 3 in 3/4 and 2 in 2/4. It is then centred in the bar. No other rest can do this.



PART II · TIME · 2 · CONTINUED

Every note has a twin rest



semibreve	**minim**	**crotchet**	**quaver**	**semiquaver**
note and rest: 4 beats	note and rest: 2 beats	note and rest: 1 beat	note and rest: ½ beat	note and rest: ¼ beat

Same length, no sound. The two big rests look alike: the **semibreve rest hangs** from line 4, heavy as a coat on a hook; the **minim rest sits** on line 3, like a hat.

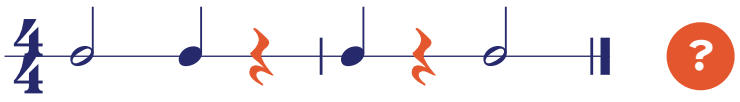
Why whole, half and quarter?

Think of each beat as a pizza. A bar of 4/4 is four pizzas. The note that fills a whole bar of 4/4 is the **whole note**; the others are a half, a quarter, an eighth and a sixteenth of it. Two quavers beamed together fill one pizza. A rest is the same share left empty: shaded with lines.

semibreve	whole note	4 pizzas · 4 beats	
semibreve rest	silence	4 beats, or a whole bar	
minim	half note	2 pizzas · 2 beats	
minim rest	silence	2 empty pizzas · 2 beats	
crotchet	quarter note	1 pizza · 1 beat	
crotchet rest	silence	1 empty pizza · 1 beat	
quaver	eighth note	half a pizza · ½ beat	
quaver rest	silence	half an empty pizza · ½ beat	
semiquaver	sixteenth note	a quarter of a pizza · ¼ beat	
semiquaver rest	silence	a quarter of an empty pizza · ¼ beat	

EXAMPLE 1

How long is each sound, and each silence?



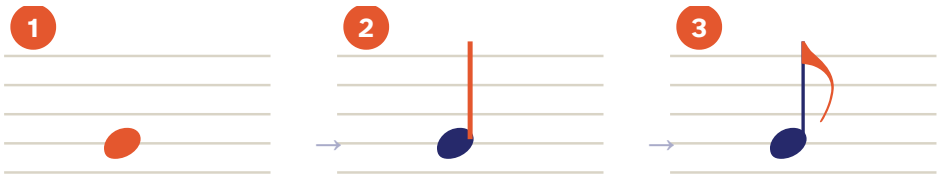
1. **Name each shape** in the bar.
2. **How many beats** does each one last?
3. **Add them up,** rests included. What is the total?

Minim 2, crotchet 1, crotchet rest 1: every bar adds up to **4 beats**, silences included.

PART II · TIME · 2 · CONTINUED

How to draw notes and rests

Draw them yourself: it is the quickest way to remember them.



an oval, tilted
filled or hollow

a stem, 3 spaces tall
up on the right

a flag, curling right
for a quaver



semibreve rest
a block hanging under line 4

minim rest
a block sitting on line 3

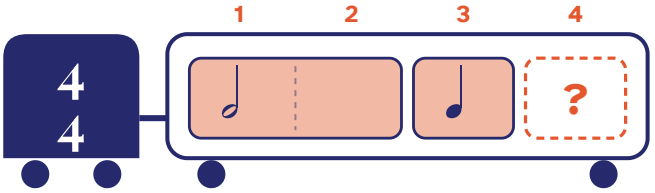
crotchet rest
draw a Z, then a little c

quaver rest
a 7 with a dot on top

semiquaver rest
a 7 with two dots

EXAMPLE 2

Fill a bar of 4/4: what goes in the last seat?
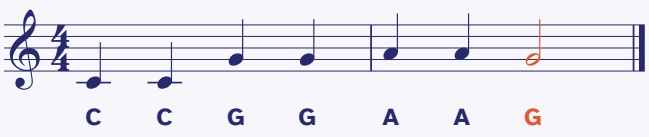


1. **How many seats** does the minim take?
2. **And the crotchet?**
3. **How many seats are left** for a silence, and which rest fills one seat?

2 + 1 = 3, one seat left: a **crotchet rest**. The bar is full.

YOU KNOW THIS

Twinkle, Twinkle, Little Star



Six **crotchets**, then a **minim** at the end of the line: one beat, one beat … and two beats to breathe.

SEE ALSO
Pulse and the bar p. 50 · How long is a note? p. 56

PRACTISE IT
Workbook pp. 3–4 · Online: Library › Notes